

DREAMING AGES HISTORY · EPISODE 2

Ancient Egypt

A Calm Journey Down the Nile

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A BEDTIME COMPANION

Two maps, a timeline from the first kings to the Rosetta Stone, the people and places you'll meet in the episode, and a short list of trusted books, museums and podcasts, for the evenings when you would like to wander a little further.

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A green ribbon through the desert

Egyptians called the dark, flood-fed soil of the valley the Black Land and the deserts on either side the Red Land. The river runs north, so Upper Egypt lies in the south and Lower Egypt in the Delta.



Sites plotted at their real locations on a modern base map (Natural Earth). The Nile's course and the coast are modern; Lake Nasser was created by the Aswan High Dam in the 1960s.

Places you'll visit in the episode

Giza: the pyramids of Khufu, Khafre and Menkaure, and the Great Sphinx.

Dahshur: the Bent and Red Pyramids, experiments on the way to the true pyramid.

Amarna: Akhenaten's new city for the Aten, abandoned after his death.

Deir el-Bahri: Hatshepsut's terraced temple, with reliefs of the voyage to Punt.

Abu Simbel: Ramesses II's rock temples, moved to higher ground in the 1960s.

Saqqara: Djoser's Step Pyramid, designed by tradition by Imhotep, in the Third Dynasty.

Memphis: the early capital, near the meeting of the valley and the Delta.

Thebes: the southern capital, with Karnak, Luxor Temple and the Valley of the Kings.

Deir el-Medina: the village of the royal tomb builders, rich in letters and records.

Alexandria: Alexander's city of 332 BCE, home of the Library and the Pharos.

THREE THOUSAND YEARS, SLOWLY

A timeline of the Nile kingdoms



Dates follow The Oxford History of Ancient Egypt; the earliest are approximate.

Before c. 3100 BCE
Naqada culture farmers and towns grow along the Nile in Upper Egypt.

c. 3100 BCE
Egypt is unified; the Narmer Palette shows a king wearing both crowns.

c. 2686–2125 BCE
The Old Kingdom.

Third Dynasty
Djoser's Step Pyramid rises at Saqqara.

Mid-26th c. BCE
The Great Pyramid of Khufu is built at Giza.

c. 2160–2055 BCE
First Intermediate Period: low floods and local rulers.

c. 2055 BCE
Egypt is reunited from Thebes: the Middle Kingdom begins.

c. 1650–1550 BCE
The Hyksos rule the north from Avaris.

c. 1550–1069 BCE
The New Kingdom, with royal tombs in the Valley of the Kings.

c. 1473–1458 BCE
Hatshepsut rules as pharaoh.

c. 1352–1336 BCE
Akhenaten worships the Aten and builds Amarna.

c. 1336–1327 BCE
The short reign of Tutankhamun.

1279–1213 BCE
The long reign of Ramesses II; Kadesh, and later a treaty with the Hittites.

c. 1157 BCE
Tomb builders of Deir el-Medina strike over late rations, under Ramesses III.

332 BCE
Alexander the Great arrives; Alexandria is founded.

31–30 BCE
Actium, and the death of Cleopatra VII; Egypt becomes a Roman province.

394 CE
The last known hieroglyphic inscription is carved at Philae.

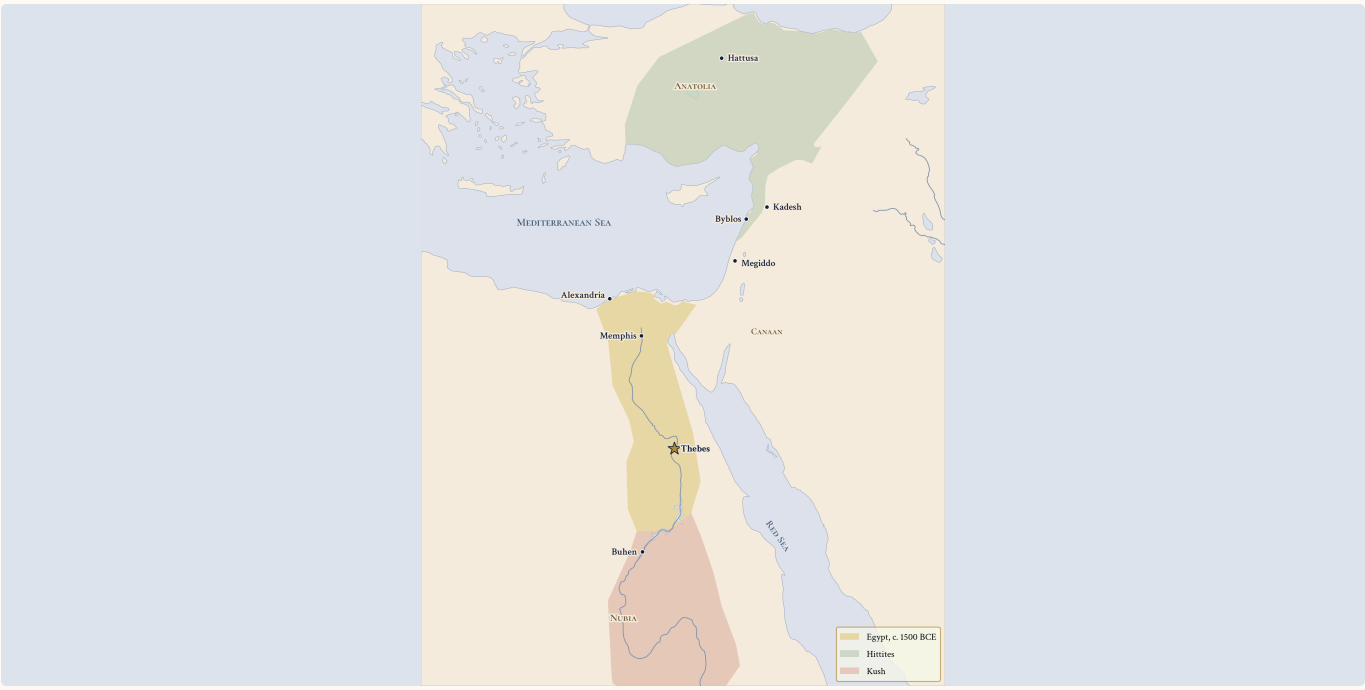
1799
The Rosetta Stone is found at Rashid.

1822
Champollion announces his decipherment of hieroglyphs.

1922
Howard Carter finds the tomb of Tutankhamun.

1964–1968
Abu Simbel is moved above the rising waters of Lake Nasser.

An empire beyond the river



Approximate extent of Egypt and its neighbours around 1500 BCE, at the start of the New Kingdom, simplified from the open historical-basemaps dataset; borders are approximate. In the following centuries Egyptian armies campaigned north to Megiddo and Kadesh and far south into Nubia.

People you'll meet

Narmer: the king of the Narmer Palette, often linked with the unification of Egypt.

Khufu: builder of the Great Pyramid of Giza, in the Fourth Dynasty.

Hatshepsut: a woman who ruled as pharaoh; builder of the temple at Deir el-Bahri.

Akhenaten & Nefertiti: the royal couple of the Aten and the city of Amarna.

Ramesses II: reigned some 66 years; builder of Abu Simbel and the Ramesseum.

Champollion: French scholar who cracked hieroglyphs in 1822, building on Thomas Young.

Imhotep: by tradition the designer of Djoser's Step Pyramid, later honoured as a sage.

Sinuhe: hero of a famous Middle Kingdom story of exile and homecoming.

Thutmose III: warrior king whose army marched through a narrow pass to Megiddo.

Tutankhamun: a young king whose nearly intact tomb was found in 1922.

Cleopatra VII: last ruler of the Ptolemaic dynasty; died in 30 BCE.

Howard Carter: archaeologist who, with Lord Carnarvon, saw "wonderful things".

Legend or history?

Some popular ideas about Egypt are not supported by the evidence. The pyramids were built by organised, rotating crews who were housed and fed at Giza, not by armies of chained slaves. And the many stories about Cleopatra come mostly from later Roman writers. The episode keeps these apart from what the sources and the monuments show.

FOR ANOTHER QUIET EVENING

Learn more





Artistic impressions of the hypostyle hall at Karnak and of Abu Simbel at sunrise, made for the episode. They are not historical records.

Books

The Rise and Fall of Ancient Egypt ↗, Toby Wilkinson (Random House, 2013).

The Oxford History of Ancient Egypt ↗, ed. Ian Shaw (Oxford University Press, 2003).

Red Land, Black Land: Daily Life in Ancient Egypt ↗, Barbara Mertz (Harper, 2009).

Temples, Tombs, and Hieroglyphs ↗, Barbara Mertz (Harper, 2009).

The Woman Who Would Be King: Hatshepsut's Rise to Power ↗, Kara Cooney (Broadway, 2015).

The Complete Gods and Goddesses of Ancient Egypt ↗, Richard H. Wilkinson (Thames & Hudson).

📚 FIND THESE BOOKS — TAP HERE →

Full reading list ↗

Museums & places

British Museum, London: the Rosetta Stone and the Papyrus of Ani.

Royal Ontario Museum, Toronto: galleries of ancient Egypt.

Museum of Fine Arts, Boston: the great Giza collection.

Rosicrucian Egyptian Museum, San Jose.

Podcasts

The History of Egypt Podcast, Dominic Perry: a long, detailed narrative history.

In Our Time: Hatshepsut, BBC Radio 4 (2014).

"Let the river slow now in your mind. Let the temples grow dim and kind. You have nowhere to be, and nothing left to carry."

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Dreaming Ages History · Narration is AI-generated text-to-speech; illustrations are AI-generated artistic impressions. Facts follow the episode script and its sources. Maps drawn from real coordinates: Natural Earth; historical borders simplified from the open historical-basemaps dataset (A. Ourednik). Free for personal use. Sleep well. 🌙